A LEVEL 1 ADVENTURE

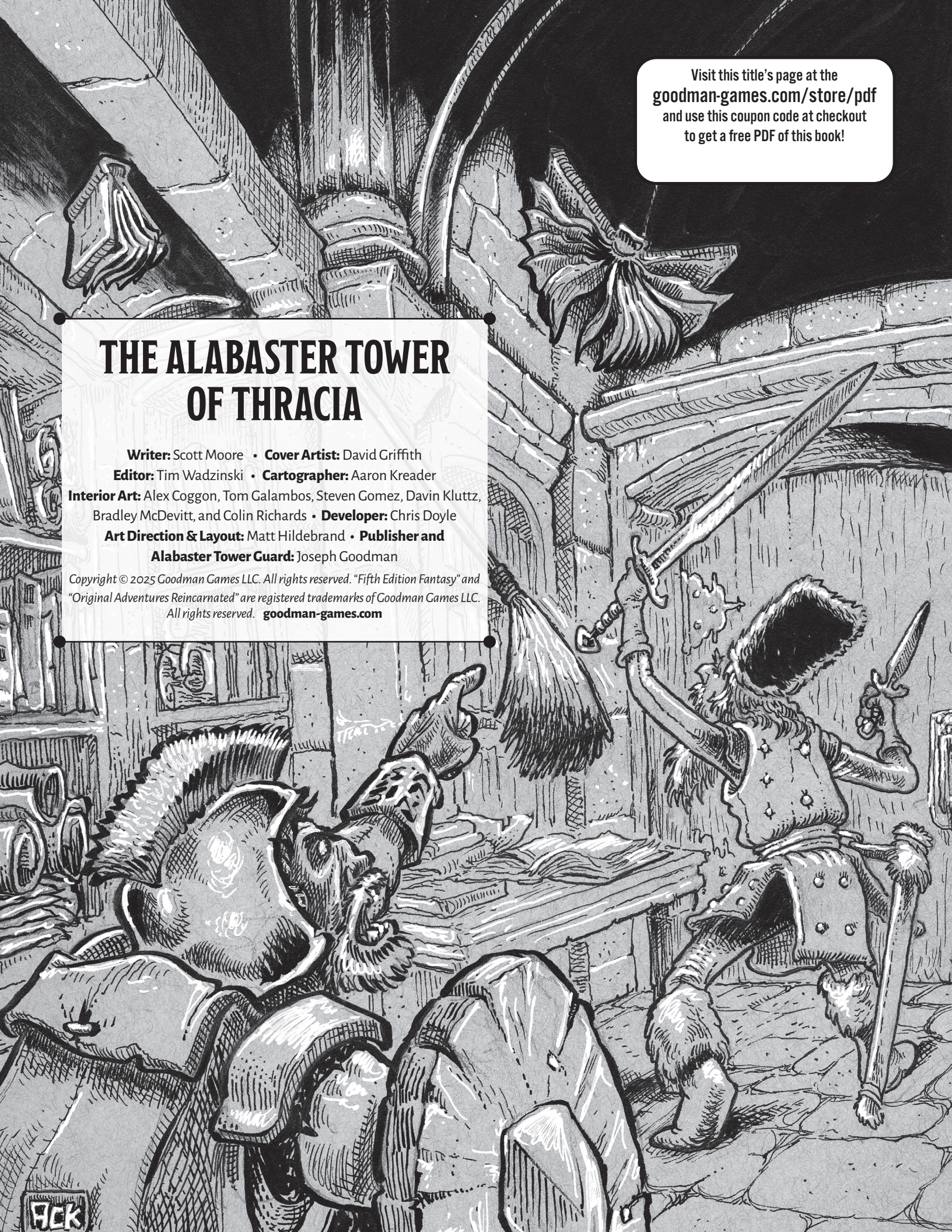
FIFTH EDITION FANTASY® #29

THE ALABASTER TOWER OF THRACIA

BY SCOTT MOORE

5E

GOODMAN GAMES



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THE ALABASTER TOWER OF THRACIA

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THE ALABASTER TOWER OF THRACIA

By Scott Moore

The Alabaster Tower of Thracia is an adventure designed for use with the fifth edition of the first fantasy role-playing game. It is intended for four to six 1st-level characters and can be completed in a few sessions. A variety of character classes is suggested to tackle the challenges within the adventure, but a cleric and one or more martial characters would be especially advantageous for the party to have. While set on the island of Thracia, home to the legendary *Caverns of Thracia*, no additional knowledge or materials are required to run this adventure.

BACKGROUND

Over a thousand years ago, before the golden age of Thracia, a young human acolyte named Upn (pronounced "OO-pen") became interested in the mysteries of life: something those in the distant future would call "biology," but no such system of study existed in Upn's days. As many do, Upn had turned to religion to seek the answers to the questions he had, eventually rising to the rank of patriarch within the city of Thracia and becoming a well-respected elder.

In secret, however, Upn—now known as "Saint Upn" due to his standing within the Thracian community—continued to research what it would take to create life himself, adding investigation of the arcane, particularly necromancy and other dark arts, to his fields of study. Saint Upn eventually began animating inanimate objects and awakening plants and small animals to see what could be divined from these "differentiated" forms of life. A little over half a millennium ago, Saint Upn even created the first "intelligent" minotaur, from which the current leader of the Thracian beastmen has descended. Not content with simply adding locomotion to furniture or granting animals the ability to speak, Upn eventually created constructs such as golems and homunculi before concluding that some element of chaos must be necessary for true life to arise from nothingness. In his mad pursuit of that elusive spark, Upn made a pact with the god of chaos, Set, promising his unwavering loyalty in exchange for the secret of creating life itself.

With the knowledge and power bestowed upon him by Set, Upn created new species of creatures that had never existed upon Thracia before, many of them seeming amalgamations of other creatures or half human/half animal monstrosities. Those who study the darkest magics attribute many of the hybrid creatures now native to Thracia, including the pervasive dogfolk, to Upn's mad practices all those centuries ago.

To the citizens of Thracia, however, Saint Upn remained a revered pillar of the community, as he managed to keep his involvement in these horrid experiments a secret for years. Some wondered how the man continued to live so long, seemingly aging very little over the decades. Most concluded it was due to his pious nature, for surely the gods must smile upon one as virtuous as Saint Upn. The truth, however, was much more horrible. Upn had become a lich in service to Set and managed to hide the truth from the populace of Thracia for centuries.

After several "accidents," where Upn's creations escaped and began to roam the wilds around Thracia, the lich moved his research (and the "zoo" he had built for his creations) to a demiplane, accessible only from two locations on the isle of Thracia: the Alabaster Towers. The Alabaster Towers are a pair of white stone towers, devoid of windows or doors, one residing in the city of Thracia and the other located among ruins seven miles north of the city. Although both towers are solid stone, when a certain magic key is brought within near proximity of either tower, a portal will open on its surface, seemingly allowing people to "enter" that tower. In actuality, they are visiting the demi-planar home and arcane research facility of Saint Upn. The key also allowed Saint Upn to "enter" one physical tower and "exit" from the other, giving him a quick and easy way to get far from the city of Thracia should he ever need to do so.

Due to the extraplanar nature of the towers, the dimensions of the seven floors contained within each one are not consistent in size between themselves; some are much smaller or much larger than others. In addition, the external dimensions of the towers have no relationship to the internal dimensions; although the towers appear 50 feet high from the outside, each of the seven floors inside both towers has a ceiling height of at least 15 feet.

The story of the discovery of Saint Upn's deceit, if it ever was discovered, has been lost to time. Roughly 380 years ago, Saint Upn disappeared from Thracia and has not been heard from since. Outside of the most esoteric books of arcane lore, the only aspects of Saint Upn's story still told are the legends of the Alabaster Tower of Thracia and how a special

key was needed to enter and discover its secrets… although there is no agreement among the legends on where exactly the Alabaster Tower was located…

THE CAVERNS OF THRACIA

If you plan on running *Original Adventures Reincarnated #9: The Caverns of Thracia* (or any of the expanded Thracia adventures) after this adventure, the following additional background information may be useful to know:

- Thanatos, worshiped by the people of Thracia centuries ago, was also a god of death, like Set.
- Saint Upn left Thracia a few short years before the worship of Thanatos was outlawed. His disappearance was wrongfully attributed to foul play on behalf of the worshipers of Thanatos, which was one of many reasons some of the citizenry began to turn against them.
- Recently, a cult worshiping The Dark One (an alternate name for Thanatos) has renewed interested in the deity among some Thracians.
- Many of the hybrid/intelligent monsters in the region (dogfolk, intelligent minotaurs, many of the creatures from *Monsters & Magic of Thracia*, etc.) were created or altered by Saint Upn's efforts.

DARK TOWER

If you plan on running *Original Adventures Reincarnated #7: Dark Tower* (including any of the expansion adventures from Volume 3 of that set) after this adventure, the following additional background information may be useful to know:

- Saint Upn was the original mortal identity of the lich later known as Pnessutt. When Saint Upn left Thracia roughly 380 years ago, he traveled to the recently uncovered ruins of Mitra's sanctuary in the village of Mitra's Fist and assumed a position of power there.
- The "fragments of uncut chrysoberyl" found in area 5-1 are the swarf remaining from the production of Pnessutt's phylactery.
- The names of Set's children (as revealed in **player handout 3** in area 6-3) will be useful for characters playing the *Dark Tower* adventures, as knowledge of these the names can provide advantages over some of the creatures therein.
- The material used to construct the interior of the tower matches the material used in the construction of the pyramid in Part 2 of the *Pocket in a Shroud* supplementary adventure.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

This adventure begins with the characters outside one of the two Alabaster Towers (either the tower in the ruins of the city of Thracia proper, or the one located seven miles away). It's up to the Game Master (GM) to decide why the characters are here, and how they get involved. A few suggestions are presented:

- A family member, close friend, or mentor that recently passed away left one of the characters an oversized key and an ancient map that led them to this site.
- An ancient treasure map and an oversized key were among the spoils from the party's recent adventure. After consulting with a sage, the characters were provided directions that would lead them to the area depicted on the map, near a mysterious alabaster tower.
- A by-product of the party's bartering negotiations with a shady merchant in town for a collection of much-needed supplies additionally netted them an odd, oversized key, and a badly weathered and fading hand-drawn map which seemed to lead to this very spot.

Quest: Explore the Tower and Learn Saint Upn's Legacy. Regardless of the hook used, the characters should encounter and defeat Saint Upn's simulacrum and be able to piece together his involvement in the creation of the hybrid monsters inhabiting Thracia.

BEGINNING THE ADVENTURE

The adventure begins when the characters arrive at one of the Alabaster Towers, standing amidst the scattered ruins of an ancient settlement. Read or paraphrase the text below, adjusting it based on the specific adventure hook utilized:

It appears the story you were given with the old key and map had at least some hint of truth to it. Before you stands a white stone tower, approximately 50 feet tall, seemingly devoid of any windows or doors. As you circumnavigate the tower's perimeter, looking for any obvious means of entry or, barring that, perhaps a hidden door, a shimmering blue ripple outlines a door-shaped portal at the base of the tower, allowing you to see inside. As you marvel at this new development, you notice the key you were given is alight with a similarly colored glow.

THE MATCHING TOWER

Of the two matching Alabaster Towers on the isle of Thracia, the one the adventurers find at the start of the adventure is left to the GM to decide.

If you plan on running the characters through *The Caverns of Thracia*, this adventure can serve as a prequel. The party can find the city and explore the tower before venturing into the caverns, or they can discover the tower in the ruins seven miles north of the city. In either case, regardless of which tower they enter, when they exit the characters find themselves transported outside the tower in the ruins of Thracia, If you are using this adventure in conjunction with previously published Thracia-related products from Goodman Games, the tower in the *Ruins of Thracia* appears at location W, while the northern tower on the *Island of Thracia* appears in hex 1409 of the maps included with those products.

Alternately, if you do not plan on running *The Caverns of Thracia*, you may place the tower wherever you wish, such as a setting convenient for whatever adventure the party will run through afterward.

THE ALABASTER TOWER

Except for Level 3, the floors and rooms of the tower within this adventure are fully depicted on **map 1**.

GENERAL FEATURES

Ceilings and Walls. The ceilings and walls inside the tower seem to be constructed from a strange, unnatural material, softer than stone (plastic-like), but almost perfectly smooth and without any signs of having been worked by tools. Because of the smoothness of the material, climbing the walls requires a successful DC 25 Strength (Athletics) check. The ceiling on each floor of the tower (except Level 3) is 15 feet high unless otherwise specified.

Climate. The air inside the tower (excluding Level 3) is extremely dry and thick with dust due to the animated cleaning staff constantly stirring it up. Every 10 minutes within the tower (except on Level 3), characters must succeed on a DC 8 Constitution save or sneeze loudly. A sneezing character automatically fails Stealth checks and has disadvantage on any attack rolls or skill checks performed during the round they sneeze. On a roll of 1 on the save, the character has a sneezing fit which lasts for 1d4 rounds.

Doors. Internal doors are constructed of wood (AC 15; 18 hit points; immunity to necrotic, poison, and psychic damage) and are unlocked unless otherwise noted in the room description.

Illumination. Although most areas within the tower have wall sconces holding torches, few of them are initially lit. Combined with the fact that there are no windows on the tower, most of the interior (except for Level 3, area 6-2, and area 7-1) is in darkness. When the characters' key is first brought near the tower, the portal that opens lets in enough light from outside for area 1-1 to be in dim light until it closes once everyone steps inside. Lighting a torch in any of the areas with wall sconces bathes the area in bright light.

Firepoles. There are several firepoles that can be utilized to quickly reach a lower level within the tower. Safely descending a firepole to reach a lower floor requires a successful DC 10 Strength (Athletics) or Dexterity (Acrobatics) check, and being proficient in both those skills grants advantage on the check. Failure results in the character falling 20 feet to the next level, resulting in 7 (2d6) bludgeoning damage. The poles are extremely smooth and nearly impossible to climb up, requiring a successful DC 30 Strength (Athletics) check to do so. Downward movement along a firepole does not cost a character any of their regular movement.

Locks. All locks in the tower (doors, cabinets, chests, desks, etc.) require a successful DC 15 Dexterity check using

thieves' tools to unlock unless otherwise specified. Alternately, the locks may be destroyed by inflicting damage (AC 19; 5 hit points; immunity to necrotic, poison, psychic, slashing, and thunder damage). If a lock is trapped, damaging the lock without disabling the trap first automatically triggers the trap. If the key to a lock exists within the scope of this adventure, its location will be specified, otherwise it is assumed to have been in the possession of Saint Upn when he last left the tower.

Time in the Tower. Time for those inside the tower passes very differently from how others entering or leaving the tower experience it. Although Saint Upn left the tower centuries ago, creatures native to the tower perceive his departure as having occurred only sometime within the last few days. Every time creatures not native to the tower (including Saint Upn and the characters) enter it, approximately 48 hours of time have passed since the last non-native visitor left, providing it happened more than two days ago from the outside world's perspective. This allows those within the tower to survive in a "living stasis," aging very slowly, perceiving the gradual passage of time, and continuing to function normally inside the tower. This also allowed Saint Upn to be outside the tower for an extended period and not find all the residents dead from hunger, thirst, or old age when he returned. Conversely, a non-native visitor entering and leaving the tower several times over the course of a single (external) day would perceive no difference in the passage of time inside and outside the tower. The time distortion is only noticeable if a visitor has not entered the tower in two days of "external world" time.

WANDERING MONSTERS

For every 15 minutes spent inside the Alabaster Tower, there is a 1 in 4 chance of a random encounter. Roll a d6 and consult the table below.

ALABASTER TOWER ENCOUNTERS

d6	Encounter
1	Animated armor
2	Animated book
3	Bamboo golem
4	Dancing brooms
5	Flying sword
6	Swarm of animated skulls

ALABASTER TOWER ENCOUNTER DESCRIPTIONS

Animated Armor. A suit of **animated armor** (plate) wanders Levels 1, 2, 4, 5, and 6 of the tower, attacking anyone who isn't one of the tower's usual inhabitants. If the armor defeats a character, it will carry the unconscious or dead body to the Duat (see area 3-2) and deposit their remains there before returning to a different level of the tower.

Animated Book. A solitary **animated book** (see appendix A), seemingly left discarded and alone, suddenly springs up and launches itself at one of the characters.

Bamboo Golem. A lone **bamboo golem** (see appendix A), created by Saint Upn, wanders Levels 1, 2, 4, 5, and 6 of the tower, attacking anyone who isn't one of the tower's regular inhabitants. If the golem defeats a character, it will carry the unconscious or dead body to the Duat (see area 3-2) and deposit their remains there before returning to a different level of the tower.

Dancing Brooms. A trio of animated, dancing brooms sweep into the characters' area, attempting to brush them aside as so much detritus. Dancing brooms are **animated brooms** (see appendix A) with the following changes:

- They have a fly speed of 30 feet.
- They have the Flyby trait: The dancing broom doesn't provoke an opportunity attack when it flies out of an enemy's reach.

Flying Sword. A **flying sword** darts about, taking swipes at random characters until reduced to half its maximum hit points or fewer, at which point it takes the Disengage action on its turn and flies away.

Swarm of Animated Skulls. Like a swarm of oversized, angry hornets, a **swarm of animated skulls** (see appendix A) flies through the tower, attacking anyone or anything that is not a typical resident of the tower.

KEY TO LEVEL 1

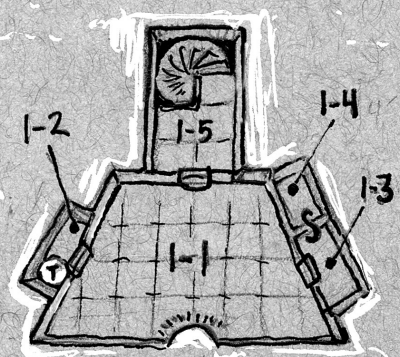
AREA 1-1 — VESTIBULE

You enter on the long side of an oddly shaped, trapezoidal room. On each of the three walls across from you is a single wooden door.

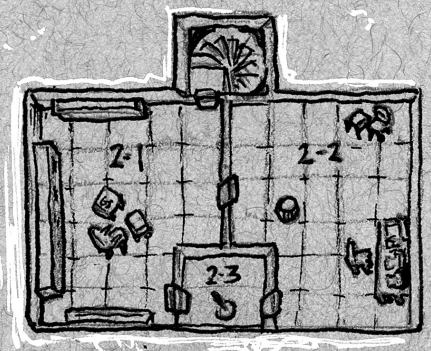
After the last character enters this room, the portal closes, putting the room into complete darkness unless someone happens to have a light source. If a character carrying the key walks up to and touches the wall where the portal appeared, it appears once again, as long as at least 10 minutes have passed since it last appeared.

MAP I

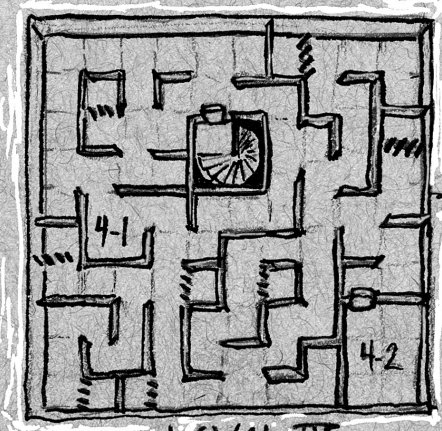
THE ALABASTER TOWER OF THRACIA



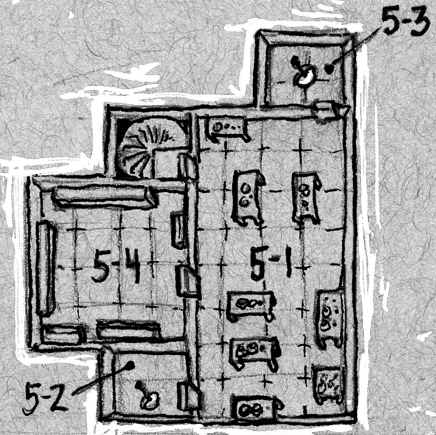
LEVEL I (GROUND)



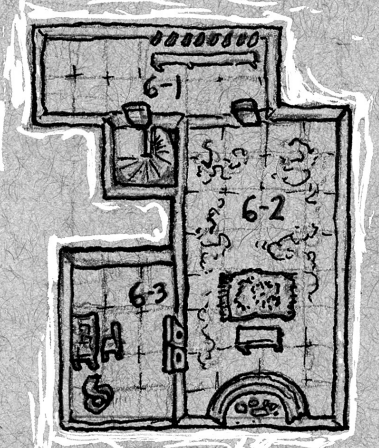
LEVEL II



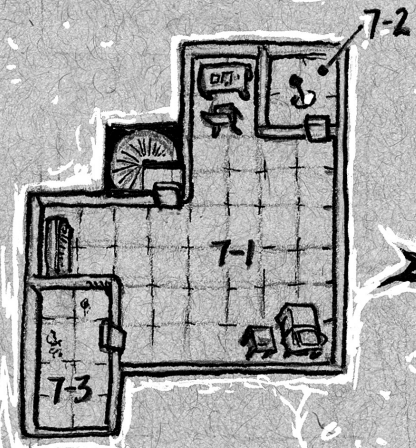
LEVEL IV



LEVEL V



LEVEL VI



LEVEL VII

□ = 5'

N

LEGEND

- PORTAL
- CELL BARS
- SPIRAL STAIRCASE
- POLE
- T TRAP
- -S- SECRET DOOR

AREA 1-2 — TRAP DOOR

Upon opening this door, a barrage of spears is fired into the room. Each of the four spears makes a ranged attack roll at +4 against a random target in area 1-1. A target that is hit takes 3 (1d6) piercing damage. Behind the door is simply the mechanism for the trap. The trap can be manually reset if the characters wish. Because the mechanism of the trap is located completely behind the door, there is no way to detect the trap from outside the closed door.

AREA 1-3 — CLOSET

Beyond this door is a small closet or cloakroom, seemingly stocked with several changes of clothes.

Several sets of common clothes, vestments, and one set of traveler's clothes hang on a rack in the back of this small closet.

Secret Door. Behind the clothing is a secret door, which requires a successful DC 20 Intelligence (Investigation) check to locate. The secret door leads to area 1-4.

AREA 1-4 — CACHE

This tiny chamber seems to have no purpose other than to conceal a small cache hidden here.

This small room served as a hiding place for Saint Upn's "grab and go" supplies, should he ever have needed to leave in a hurry or for an extended period.

Treasure. Crammed into this small space is a belt pouch containing 10 sp and 10 gp (of ancient Thracian design), a diplomat's pack (39 gp), an explorer's pack (10 gp), and a *potion of healing*.

AREA 1-5 — STAIRWAY

On the other side of the wooden door is a small 10-foot-by-10-foot room. On the opposite side of the room is a spiral staircase which ascends further into the tower.

This room provides access to the staircase to Level 2.

KEY TO LEVEL 2

AREA 2-1 — LIBRARY

Bookshelves constructed of rich, dark wood line of the walls of this room. The shelves are filled with assorted books of various sizes. In the center of the room sits a deep red plush chair with golden knotwork trim, a matching ottoman, and a small side table, seemingly constructed from the same dark wood as the bookshelves. Several open tomes lie scattered about the room.

With a successful DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check, a character notices the open books are all somewhere in their first few pages. Those with bookmarks or ribbons mark pages very near the beginning of each book. Saint Upn's simulacrum (see area 7-1) occasionally stops here to relax and read a book, as Saint Upn himself frequently used to do. Since simulacrums lack the ability to learn, however, the creature tends to read a single page, over and over, until it becomes bored or its attention is drawn elsewhere, at which point it marks its place and puts the book down, meaning to return to it again at some point.

With a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check, a character discovers an old journal among the shelved books. This journal was once used by Saint Upn himself and contains numerous mundane entries about his life in Thracia. The final entry, however, contains the cleric's musings on "life" and may begin to give the characters insight into Saint Upn's decline into a "mad scientist" (see **player handout 1**).

Nine of the open tomes are **animated books** (see appendix A) that attack whoever touches them except for Saint Upn and his simulacrum.

The books on the shelves are in remarkably good condition and if the characters spend time looking through them, they discover tomes covering topics of biology, necromancy, constructs, transmutation, and religious and philosophical treatises on the origins of life. The books are primarily written in Common, but a non-insignificant number of them are in Abyssal.

Treasure. With a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check, characters discover *spell scrolls* of *animate dead*, *animate objects*, and *comprehend languages* in a folio on one of the shelves. Although the books are quite old, none of them are particularly noteworthy or of appreciable value outside of the knowledge they contain.

Development: If any of the books are removed from the tower, they become **animated books** (see appendix A) and attack those responsible for removing them.

AREA 2-2 — STUDY

This wood-paneled room gives the impression of having once served as a den or study. A large writing desk sits against one wall, accompanied by a chair, while a larger, second chair sits off to one side, next to a small table. Several framed pieces of art hang on the walls. A single wooden barrel stands in the middle of the room.

The wooden barrel is a **mimic** that attacks anyone other than a resident of the tower that approaches within 5 feet of it. Otherwise, it remains docile and is viewed by those residing within the tower as a faithful, if lazy, pet.

Treasure. Much of the framed artwork on the walls in unremarkable except for a framed sword which is a magical *+1 longsword*.

AREA 2-3 — FIREPOLE FROM THE LAB

This small room is devoid of any furnishings or décor save for a 3-inch-diameter smooth metal cylinder, mounted to the floor and extending up through a 4-foot-diameter hole in the ceiling.

This firepole descends from area 5-2, bypassing the third and fourth levels completely. Regardless of the "floors" that exist between this area and area 5-2, travel along the firepole seems to cover a total distance of 20 feet and no other adjacent areas are observed while traveling along the firepole.

KEY TO LEVEL 3

The regions of the Duat, occupying the space between the second and fourth levels of the tower, are fully depicted on **map 2**.

AREA 3-1 — GATEWAY TO THE DUAT

Across this small alcove is a solitary wooden door, seemingly crafted from a single slab of ironwood. A circle containing a five-pointed star has been neatly carved into the door.

A successful DC 20 Intelligence (Religion) check recognizes the symbol on the door as representing the Duat, a concept of the underworld or the afterlife in some religions not typically associated with the people of Thracia.

The door is not locked or trapped, per se, but it is a **wood door golem** (see appendix A) that attacks anyone that is not a resident of the tower that comes within range. If reduced to 0 hit points, the door remains in place and functions as a normal door.

The portal guarded by the wood door golem has an additional magical protection on it which prevents residents of the

THE DUAT

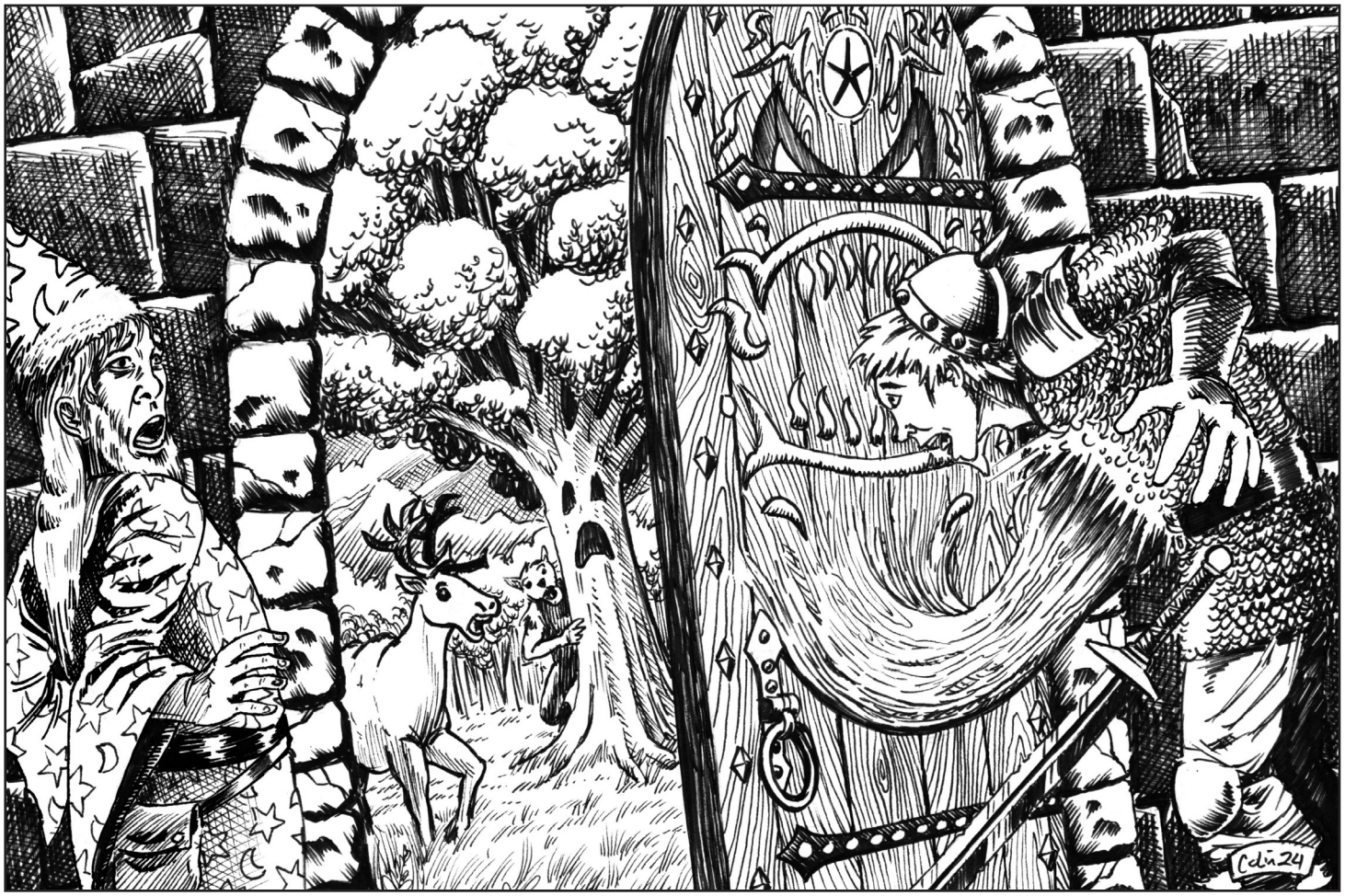
On the other side of the wood door golem in area 3-1 is a simulated magical biome that exists on its own demiplane apart from the tower itself. The area of the demiplane is a circle of approximately 2 square miles (about 8/10ths of a mile in radius), covered by an opaque, hemispheric dome that resembles a gray, overcast sky from the ground below. The top of the dome emits bright light for a period of 14 hours, followed by dim light for 2 hours, no light (darkness) for 6 hours, and then dim light again for 2 hours before repeating the pattern, providing the area with a simulation of daylight. Temperatures vary based on the time and location within the area, but the "days" are typically cool to warm and the dark periods noticeably cooler but never cold. Saint Upn named this area the Duat, after the name of the underworld used by followers of Set. The edge of the Duat is simply a solid, opaque wall which cannot be damaged or passed through.

The Duat serves as the home for many of Saint Upn's creations, or at least the ones that he did not release (or that escaped) from the tower to Thracia. The creatures that reside here are content in their pocket paradise and have no interest in leaving (although a few dogfolk may be convinced—see area 3-2). Saint Upn would occasionally discard unwanted items (the occasional book, an extra loaf of bread, or excess produce) into the Duat, which the residents always saw as a gift from their maker. On the rare occasion Saint Upn needed to dispose of a body, it was usually dumped here and composted, consumed, or otherwise used as fishing bait by the residents.

The Duat contains five different climate regions: fog desert, grasslands, rainforest, sea, and swamp. Each of these is a magical simulation of what a real-world region of this type would look like. To those proficient in the Nature skill, certain traits in each area may hint at the fact that these are not truly natural areas. Under a casting of *detect magic*, the entire Duat radiates conjuration magic.

After exploring at least one climate area, if a character who is proficient in Nature or Survival inquires about the setting (types of trees in the forest, seashells on the beach, fish in the ocean, etc.) and succeeds on a DC 26 Intelligence (Nature) or Wisdom (Survival) check, they realize that the "natural" elements of the Duat are not natural at all, but appear to be created based on someone's idea of what generic plants and animals should look like. This is similar to how the servants conjured in a magnificent mansion spell appear as extremely lifelike conjurations. The DC for this check is reduced by 4 for every additional climate area a character visits (down to DC 10 after visiting all five areas, from 3-2 through 3-6). The description of each climate area contains details of the natural elements that are "off" in each section.

From within the Duat, characters can no longer see the spiral staircase from which they reached this level. They can, however, see the portal that grants access between the landing on the spiral staircase (in area 3-1) freely standing in the middle of the grasslands, as if it were a tear in space.



Duat from exiting this level unless accompanied by a non-resident of the tower. Normally, this would only be Saint Upn himself, but the characters also fit this qualification.

The spiral staircase continues up from this landing to the door outside of area 4-1. Heading down the spiral staircase from here leads to the landing and door outside of area 2-1.

AREA 3-2 — GRASSLANDS

This expansive plain of tall grasses stretches far into the distance, disappearing into jungle or fog-cloaked hills. Small birds fly seemingly random paths high overhead, while the buzzing and chirping of unseen insects surrounds you. Matted-down grass trails imply creatures pass through these grasslands with some frequency.

The grasses on this plain primarily grow between 3 and 4 feet in height, although smaller varieties can be found. Like many aspects of the environment here in the Duat, the grass, birds, and insects found throughout the region are magical conjurations. The grain found on the grasses, however, is edible and can be prepared, utilized, and consumed in a manner identical to wheat without any ill effects.

Two packs of **dogfolk** (see appendix A), each with three members, reside within the grasslands. Each of the six has the face, hair, and coloration of a different type of domesticated dog. All of them speak Common rather than Gnoll, the latter being something that was picked up and passed down by the original dogfolk that first escaped from the tower. Their initial reaction to Humanoid visitors is cautious but friendly, as Humanoids remind them of Saint Upn, their creator. Convincing the dogfolk to leave the Duat can only be accomplished with a successful DC 25 Charisma-based skill check, and only a maximum of three can be convinced to leave. Once out of the Duat, the dogfolk get "the zoomies" and wildly run throughout the tower, excitedly exploring it, getting into trouble, and alerting the tower's other occupants of the characters' presence. If somehow permitted to leave the tower, the dogfolk immediately and excitedly run off and abandon the party.

There are several well-established trails zigzagging across the grasslands (requiring only a successful DC 10 Wisdom [Survival] check to follow) that lead to the sea (area 3-3), rainforest (area 3-6), and river (area 3-7) areas. Traveling off-trail through the grasslands counts as difficult terrain due to the height and thickness of the grasses.

Development. Tarands from the rainforest (area 3-6) occasionally wander into the grasslands to consume grain, but try to avoid the dogfolk, who enjoy chasing them.

AREA 3-3 — SEA

A large body of water stretches far away, disappearing into the distance without a noticeable horizon as it blends into the overcast sky. Gentle waves lazily lap the sandy shore, occasionally exposing a partially buried seashell. Yards away, a lone fish leaps into the air before quickly disappearing below the surface again.

The sea is populated by "fish" of a type unknown in the outside world. Each fish is covered in large silver scales and falls between 7 and 10 inches in length. They are surprisingly easy to catch, requiring nothing more than standard fishing tackle, something that could pass as bait or a lure, and several minutes of patience. Regardless of the number of fish caught, their numbers never noticeably deplete. The "fish" are not truly living creatures, but they are edible, each one providing a satisfying meal for a single Medium creature.

The shoreline is a fine-grained mixture of pinkish sand, as is the entire sea bottom; it is completely devoid of any aquatic plant growth. The slope of the seashore into the salt water is gradual enough that the water is only about 5 feet deep 30 feet from shore.

AREA 3-4 — SWAMP

Adjacent to a large body of water, a thicket of mangrove trees provides a swamp-like region of shallow wetlands where the trees' densely twisting aerial roots make it appear like a forest on stilts.

A solitary **phorcides' follicle** (see appendix A) resides in the swamp. According to the ancient legends surrounding them, the medusa-like phorcides shed their green, snake-like appendages like mammals shed hair, but with a significant difference: the shed snakes are capable of petrifying those that gaze upon them. This particular creature typically keeps to itself and feeds off "fish" (identical to those in area 3-3) it preys upon in the swamp, avoiding contact with the other creatures in the Duat. If it becomes aware of other creatures wandering nearby, it will hide until it believes they have passed, preferring to avoid contact. If confronted, it will defend itself.

AREA 3-5 — FOG DESERT

This desert area surprisingly shows many signs of life, as several different cacti and succulents are visible throughout the sandy expanse. The region seems to be at least partially bordered by a thick wall of fog which provides a noticeable and unexpectedly high level of moisture in the air here. Tracks in the sand indicate that at least some creatures travel through this area regularly.

This area is a fog desert. Due to the interaction of the air over this region and the sea (area 3-3), an obscuring fog lingers over this desert from shortly after the Duat begins entering darkness until several hours after light once again begins to appear. During these early "morning hours," no horizon or sky is discernable, as the fog blends the sky into the desert, creating a disconcerting effect for observers.

This regular fog provides moisture which is absorbed by the plants throughout the region. These "plants" are not natural growths but are magical conjurations resembling cacti and succulents. Any skill checks attempting to accurately identify the specific types will fail. Slicing one of the artificial plants open will reveal enough water to fill a standard waterskin. Several of the cacti bear pale purple or red "fruits" that may be consumed as food and have a mildly sweet taste to them. Regardless of the number of fruits or plants harvested, their number is seemingly replaced by new growth within days.

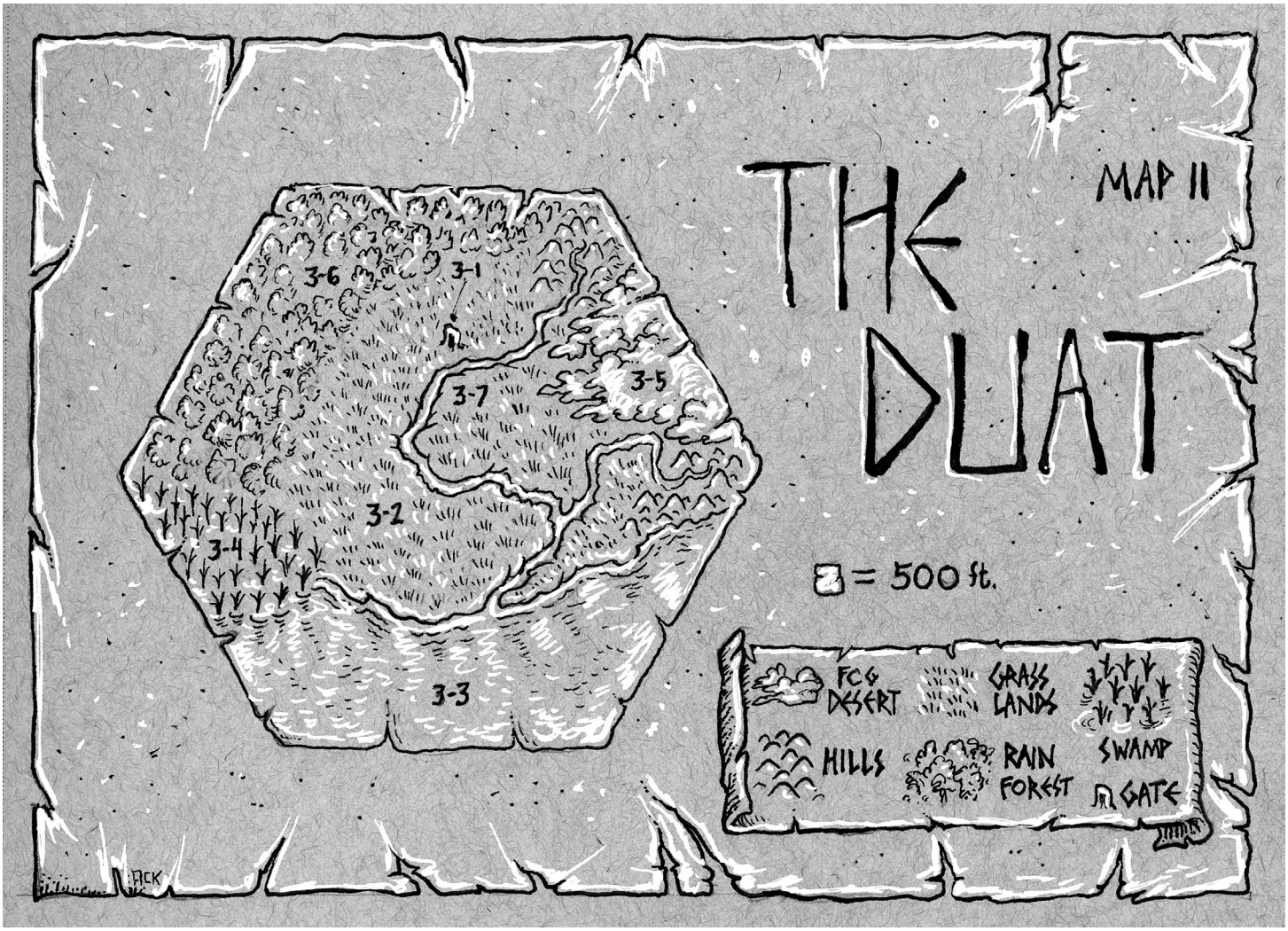
Development. Tarands (see area 3-6) and dogfolk (see area 3-2) occasionally wander into the desert to feed on the fruits, but typically do so only late in the daily light period and make sure they are out of the desert before dark comes.

AREA 3-6 — RAINFOREST

The air feels heavy and humid in this area. Tall trees, densely packed together, block out much of the overhead light but well-worn and recently traveled paths can still be seen disappearing into the forest darkness ahead.

This rainforest consists of tall, densely crowned trees which block out most of the light during the periods of "daylight" in the Duat. A second layer of dense plant growth covers the forest floor. Most of the trees produce nuts or fruit, while many of the plants along the forest floor produce berries of different colors, but uniform shape, resembling blueberries or huckleberries. Nature or Survival checks made to identify the berries or mast are unsuccessful, as they are all artificial creations, much like the "fish" in the water areas. All berries, fruits, and nuts are edible, and have flavors vaguely resembling the type of food they resemble (fruits and berries are a mix of sweet and sour, nuts are a mix of bitter and sweet). If a tree is felled, it is found to be made of a wood-like substance and can be used as such, but there are no tree rings visible in cross-sections of the trunks. Despite the amount of food harvested or the number of trees felled, the population of those items in the rainforest never noticeably diminishes.

In addition to the artificial plant life in this region, characters passing through the area will also be aware of the occasional bird sound or buzzing insect. These, too, are artificial creations, with the birds being brightly colored, through generic, representations of actual birds, and the insects nothing more than tiny, buzzing annoyances (they do not bite or sting). This region is noticeably warmer and more humid than the neighboring regions.



An **awakened tree** and nine **awakened shrubs** (all capable of communicating in Common) reside in the rainforest, never having a reason to leave. A group of six **tarands** (see appendix A) also live in the rainforest, as it provides them with easy cover in which to hide. Tarands are large deer, similar in appearance to moose or reindeer, with an innate chameleon-like ability to change the color of their hair to camouflage themselves. These timid creatures occasionally wander the grasslands (area 3-2) or to the river (area 3-7) but tend to avoid the other regions of the Duat. Wildlife trails indicating the creatures' travel can be spotted through the ground cover of the rainforest with successful DC 12 Wisdom (Perception or Survival) checks.

AREA 3-7 — RIVER

This slow-moving river flows down from the hills, cutting through the grasslands before emptying into the sea near the swamp. From what you've seen, the river tends to vary from 50 to 60 feet in width, although you are uncertain of its depth. Near the shore, the water is surprisingly clear and flows over a riverbed of well-worn stone with no noticeable aquatic plant growth or rapids breaking its surface.

The water in the river is clear and safe to drink. The waterway is populated by "fish" identical to those found in the sea (area 3-3) and adjacent swamp (area 3-4). With a successful DC 10 Intelligence (Nature) check, characters observing the fish in both fresh and saltwater environments realize just how rare euryhaline fish like these are. These creatures are edible and easy to catch, as described in area 3-3. The riverbed consists of well-weathered stones and pebbles of various sizes and colors, similar to, but much larger than, the multicolored gravel used in some fish tanks.

KEY TO LEVEL 4

AREA 4-1 — THE LABYRINTHINE MENAGERIE

Winding passages conceal numerous abandoned cells, each fronted by closely spaced vertical bars and a similar lockable door, giving one the impression of a bizarre, abandoned zoo, kennel, or prison… or some disturbing combination of those…

Stalking the hallways of the area is a single **minotaur skel-**

eton, all that remains of one of Saint Upn's unsuccessful early efforts to bestow a greater degree of intelligence to these bestial hybrid creatures. Because of its Large size, the skeleton must squeeze through most of the corridors of this area, which effectively cuts its movement rate in half and imposes disadvantage on its attack rolls and Dexterity saving throws. The creature attacks anyone that is not one of the tower's usual residents. It will not leave this level.

These prison cells once housed some of Saint Upn's creatures before he created the Duat (see the sidebar near "Key to Level 3") to serve as a larger and more permanent home for them.

AREA 4-2 — CORPSE IN A BOX

This room is completely empty except for an upright, wooden casket standing against the far wall.

If characters begin to enter the room, the coffin door springs open, releasing a fast-moving **zombie** (speed of 30 feet) that has an enhanced Bite attack it may optionally use in place of its Slam attack:

Bite: *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) piercing damage plus the target must succeed on a DC 13 Constitution save or experience redness, swelling, itching, and the smell of decaying flesh at the site of the injury for the next 2 (1d4) days unless the wound is magically healed.

The coffin itself is an **animated coffin** (see appendix A) which immediately attacks the party after releasing the zombie, which also attacks the party.

KEY TO LEVEL 5

AREA 5-1 — LAB

Numerous tables and workbenches filled with various beakers, flasks, and other glassware, some still containing fluids in a spectrum of colors, crowd this room and give one the impression of having entered a laboratory. Two large cabinets stand against the far wall of the room while four doors lie around the room's perimeter.

Inside the two cabinets are additional beakers, flasks, and other commonly used scientific equipment, as well as a stack of research notes containing **player handout 2**.

Treasure. If the material laid out on the tables and workbenches is collected, it is the equivalent of one set of alchemist's supplies (50 gp). Among the fluids contained in the glass vessels around the room are a dose of acid (25 gp), antitoxin (50 gp), and holy water (25 gp). Among the research notes found in one of the cabinets is a folded-up *spell scroll* of *awaken*. In the other cabinet is a small gauze pouch containing several fragments of uncut chrysoberyl (100 gp).

Development. If the characters are not careful of their volume in this room, they will alert the homunculus in area 5-4, who will come to explore the source of the noise. Upon spotting the characters, the creature immediately heads to area 5-3 and flies up the shaft to alert Saint Upn's simulacrum (see area 7-1) about the intruders. Since the homunculus doesn't speak and the simulacrum is not its master (Saint Upn is), the creature is forced to use pantomime to communicate, resulting in the simulacrum taking 1d4 rounds to decipher the homunculus's intended message.

AREA 5-2 — FIREPOLE TO RESEARCH AREA

This small room is devoid of any furnishings or décor save for a 3-inch-diameter smooth metal cylinder, mounted to the ceiling and extending down through a 4-foot-diameter hole in the floor.

This firepole allows for quick passage from this floor down to area 2-3 on Level 2, bypassing the third and fourth levels completely. Regardless of the "floors" that exist between this area and area 2-3, travel along the firepole seems to cover a total distance of 20 feet and no other adjacent areas are observed while traveling along the firepole.

AREA 5-3 — FIREPOLE FROM BEDROOM

This alcove is devoid of any furnishings or décor save for a 3-inch-diameter smooth metal cylinder, mounted to the floor and extending up through a 4-foot-diameter hole in the ceiling.

This firepole allows for quick passage from area 7-2 down to this area, bypassing the sixth level completely. Regardless of the "floor" that seemingly exists between this area and the seventh level, travel along the firepole seems to cover a total distance of 20 feet and no other adjacent areas are observed while traveling along the firepole.

AREA 5-4 — SUPPLY CLOSET

Rows of shelving filled with various glassware, lab equipment, and sealed test tubes of various samples line the walls of this 20-foot-by-20-foot storage room. A short, locked wooden cabinet sits in the corner of the room.

A single **homunculus** takes a visual inventory of its master's supplies in this room. If the creature was not previously aware of the characters' presence in the tower, it immediately panics upon encountering them, heads to area 5-3, and flies up the shaft to alert Saint Upn's simulacrum (see area 7-1) about the intruders. Since the homunculus doesn't speak and the simulacrum is not its master (Saint Upn is), the creature is forced to use pantomime to communicate, resulting in the simulacrum taking 1d4 rounds to decipher the homunculus's intended message before it can respond.

The glassware on the shelves are additional supplies for the lab in area 5-1. The interior walls of the cabinet are lined cotton and wool, which becomes obvious once the cabinet is opened. The temperature inside the cabinet is noticeably colder than the surrounding room. Inside the cabinet are dozens of sealed vials of biological material, each labeled with the source of the internal material (ex: "chameleon," "cow," "dog (poodle)," "dragon (bile)," "giant (hill)," giant (stone)," "gnoll," "gnome (deep)," "reindeer," "zombie," etc.).

Treasure. Inside the cabinet with the vials is a transparent blue quartz crystal (10 gp) which always feels cold to the touch and seems to chill anything that is close or in contact with it, essentially acting as a perpetual ice cube. It is the source of the refrigeration effect inside of the cabinet. Materials within the vials will decompose within 48 hours if removed from the crystal's presence without an alternative means of keeping the materials cool.

KEY TO LEVEL 6

AREA 6-1 — PREPARATION CHAMBER

This cloakroom contains a single wooden bench along one wall below a row of wooden pegs for holding cloaks or robes set roughly 5 feet above the floor. Besides the door from which you entered, there is a second door providing another way out of the room.

A successful DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check reveals a pair of cloth slippers crumpled up underneath the bench. A character who removes their regular footwear and wears these slippers (they are far too small to fit over anything but one's bare feet) into area 6-2 will be ignored by the poisonous snakes in that chamber unless they attack them or cast a spell affecting them.

AREA 6-2 — TEMPLE

This area appears to be a chapel or temple. On the far side of the room, several steps lead up to a small altar topped with several idols and fetishes. A low table sits on the ground before the altar, with a prayer rug placed before it. Numerous curving patterns are carved or etched into the floor here. Several dying braziers hang from the ceiling along the sides of the room, proving a soft, dim glow to the area. Recently burned incense, still visible as a lightly obscuring haze over the room, provides an unfamiliar, but not unpleasant, odor to the room. A pair of double doors appears further down the wall to your right.

Saint Upn's simulacrum (see area 7-1) was recently here, having performed its daily rites to Set. The simulacrum snuffed, but did not fully extinguish, the braziers whose embers now provide dim illumination. The dim light, combined with the lightly obscuring haze and scent of recently burned incense, imposes disadvantage on all Wisdom (Perception) checks made in the room that rely on sight or smell.

If anyone other than Saint Upn or any of the tower's other native residents enter this room, the curving patterns on the floor transform into six **poisonous snakes**. There are a total of six tiny reptile-themed fetishes, constructed of bones, sinew, and molted snakeskin, on the altar. The snakes will not enter a 5-foot square that contains one of the fetishes, so characters who realize this can disperse the fetishes around the room to move with minimal interference from the snakes. If the characters leave the room, the snakes (if still active) once again go dormant, transforming back into the elaborate designs upon the floor. If the room is reentered by creatures not native to the tower, the snakes reappear, fully healed.

Treasure. The prayer rug is in excellent condition and depicts a simplified map of ancient Thracia (10 gp).

AREA 6-3 — SANCTUM

GM Note: The doors to this room are locked.

This small office contains a single chair and a desk strewn with papers. Various snake-themed pieces of art are stationed around the room, including a 5-foot-tall primitive wood carved statue of a rearing snake standing in the corner of the room.

THE SIMULACRUM'S STORY

During one of several phases of his research into magically created "life", Upn had a simulacrum created in his own image in hopes of better understanding the nature of constructs. As a cleric, Upn did not have access to the requisite spell necessary to create a simulacrum and so he petitioned a hermit wizard of elven descent known as Demeter, with whom Upn had become acquainted, to create the simulacrum for him. Demeter's single command to the simulacrum was "do as Saint Upn commands you."

Upn eventually came to regard the simulacrum as his assistant and left it in charge of managing the Alabaster Tower whenever he was away. The simulacrum will attack any creature it encounters within the tower that is not Saint Upn, a companion of his, or another resident of the tower. If severely damaged in defense of the tower, Saint Upn has given the simulacrum permission to leave the tower, locate one or more of the Saint's hidden caches on the island of Thracia, seek out its original creator and present itself for repairs, offering the recovered caches as payment, before returning to the tower.

The location, as well as the contents, of the hidden caches are outside the scope of this adventure, as it the current fate of Demeter. These elements of the simulacrum's background are presented for the GM to potentially utilize in expanding this adventure.

The carved snake statue appears quite old. Visible spots of color on the statue's surface imply it may have been fully painted at one time, but most of the color has weathered away. The statue is secretly an elaborate cabinet with a hidden compartment in its middle which can be discovered with a successful DC 13 Intelligence (Investigation) check.

The snake-themed artwork throughout the room consists of small paintings on slate, tiny figurines, and other fetishes like those found on the altar in area 6-2. None of these items have any impact on the poisonous snakes found in that room. Any character examining the art pieces that succeeds on a DC 12 Intelligence (Religion) check notices symbols and imagery among the artwork tied to the ancient god Set.

Searching the papers on the desk reveals a note referencing various children of Set, questions about Set's relationship to another deity of the death worshiped in Thracia, and musings about Set's ability to create life (see **player handout 3**).

Treasure. Inside the hidden cabinet drawer is the contents of a priest's pack (19 gp).

KEY TO LEVEL 7

AREA 7-1 — BEDROOM

This rather comfortable bedroom houses a large, oversized bed, nightstand, desk, chair, and a small bookshelf. Several paintings hang on the walls. There are three doors off this room including the one from which you entered. Soft illumination radiates from the ceiling.

A simulacrum of Saint Upn is present in this room when the characters first arrive. The simulacrum is not interested in conversing with the characters and according to its somewhat vague instructions, sees them simply as invaders who must be dealt with.

Treat the simulacrum as a **priest** with the following changes:

- It is a Neutral Evil Medium Construct
- It has 14 (2d8 + 5) hit points
- It speaks Abyssal, Common, and Thracian (a local human dialect)
- Replace *lesser restoration* in its spell list with *aid*
- The simulacrum can be dispelled with a *dispel magic* (against a DC 17 spellcheck)

Paperwork in the desk drawer includes the final notes written by Saint Upn / Pnessutt before he left the tower for the last time. If the desk is searched, provide the players with **player handout 4**. The ceiling is enchanted with a *continual flame* spell.

Treasure. There are a total of five paintings on the walls, four of which show jungle scenes at different times of the day and the fifth depicting a vague shadowy figure skulking through a cityscape at dusk. The paintings are worth 25 gp each to an art collector. Sitting on the desk is a *helm of comprehending languages*, and in one of its drawers are a pair of *goggles of night* and a *periapt of wound closure*. The simulacrum also carries a second key to the tower, identical to the one carried by the characters.

Developments. If the simulacrum is not confident in its ability to defeat the party, it will open the door to area 7-3 and release the two **skeletons** kept there to attack the party as well. If the simulacrum is aware of the characters' presence in

the tower before they enter this room, it has already released the skeletons from area 7-3, cast *spirit guardians* (with the skeletons unaffected), and cast *aid* on itself and the skeletons.

AREA 7-2 — FIREPOLE TO THE LAB

This alcove is devoid of any furnishings or décor save for a 3-inch-diameter smooth metal cylinder, mounted to the ceiling and extending down through a 4-foot-diameter hole in the floor.

This firepole descends to area 5-3, bypassing the sixth level completely. Regardless of the "floor" that exists between this area and area 5-3, travel along the firepole seems to cover a total distance of 20 feet and no other adjacent areas are observed while traveling along the firepole.

AREA 7-3 — SKELETONS IN THE CLOSET

GM Note: The two undead creatures waiting in this room are completely silent and motionless, making them nearly impossible to detect until someone opens the door. They then burst forth, attacking anyone in the room that is not a resident of the tower.

Two humanoid skeletons, clad in armor scraps and wielding weapons, burst forth from this small closest, and attack without mercy.

These are a pair of normal Humanoid **skeletons**. In addition to their shortswords and shortbows, each of them wears a quiver containing 20 arrows.

Treasure. In the back of the closest is a *staff of the adder*, which once belonged to Saint Upn.

CONCLUDING THE ADVENTURE

If Saint Upn's simulacrum manages to escape from the characters and exit the tower, it ends up in a different location than the characters when they leave (see "The Matching Towers" sidebar). In this case, assume the simulacrum has access to caches left behind in the "real" world by Saint Upn and that it uses those resources to and better equip itself before trying to hunt down the characters or return to the tower. If the simulacrum locates its original wizard creator, it can heal itself as described in the spell's description.

If the characters have not yet discovered the ruins of Thracia (or if they entered the tower in Thracia and exited elsewhere), the map on the prayer rug from the temple (area 6-2) provides enough detail for the characters to find their way there.

Finally, if the characters manage to clear out the tower (or at least all of it except the Duat on Level 3), they could take over the tower as their own and use it as a base of operations while exploring the local region, assuming they still have at least one of the keys to enter it.

Awarding Experience. If the characters successfully completed the quest for this adventure and/or if you plan on running *The Caverns of Thracia* as an immediate follow-up to this adventure, allow them to advance to their next level.

APPENDIX A: NEW MONSTERS

ANIMATED BOOK

Tiny Construct, Unaligned

Armor Class: 12

Hit Points: 5 (2d4)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
6 (-2)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	1 (-5)	3 (-4)	1 (-5)

Damage Vulnerabilities: fire

Damage Immunities: poison, psychic

Condition Immunities: blinded, charmed, deafened, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned

Senses: blindsight 60 ft. (blind beyond this radius), passive Perception 6

Languages: —

Challenge: 0 (10 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

Antimagic Susceptibility: The animated book is incapacitated while in the area of an *antimagic field*. If targeted by *dispel magic*, the animated book must succeed on a Constitution saving throw against the caster's spell save DC or fall unconscious for 1 minute.

False Appearance: While the animated book remains motionless, it is indistinguishable from a normal book.

Unusual Nature: The animated book doesn't require air, food, drink or sleep.

ACTIONS

Slam: *Melee Weapon Attack:* +0 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 1 (1d4 - 2) bludgeoning damage.

A seemingly normal book falls off the bookshelf and lands at your feet. Soon, all the books begin to flop about, snapping at your exposed legs like hungry wolf cubs.

ANIMATED BROOM

Small Construct, Unaligned

Armor Class: 13

Hit Points: 7 (2d6)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
6 (-2)	16 (+3)	10 (+0)	1 (-5)	3 (-4)	1 (-5)

Damage Vulnerabilities: fire

Damage Immunities: poison, psychic

Condition Immunities: blinded, charmed, deafened, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned

Senses: blindsight 60 ft. (blind beyond this radius), passive Perception 6

Languages: —

Challenge: 1/8 (25 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

Antimagic Susceptibility: The animated broom is incapacitated while in the area of an *antimagic field*. If targeted by *dispel magic*, the animated broom must succeed on a Constitution saving throw against the caster's spell save DC or fall unconscious for 1 minute.

False Appearance: While the animated broom remains motionless, it is indistinguishable from a normal broom.

Unusual Nature: The animated broom doesn't require air, food, drink or sleep.

ACTIONS

Slam: *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) bludgeoning damage.

Dusty Slam (Recharge 6): *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* Target creature must make a successful DC 10 Constitution check or become blinded until the end of its next turn.

What appeared to be an ordinary broom springs to action on its own, dancing and sweeping its bristles along the dusty floor. With surprising deftness, it flips up its bristled end and slams into its target, releasing a thick cloud of dust.

ANIMATED COFFIN

Medium Construct, Unaligned

Armor Class: 15 (natural armor)

Hit Points: 33 (6d8 + 6)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
14 (+2)	10 (+0)	12 (+1)	1 (-5)	3 (-4)	1 (-5)

Damage Vulnerabilities: fire

Damage Immunities: poison, psychic

Condition Immunities: blinded, charmed, deafened, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned

Senses: blindsight 60 ft. (blind beyond this radius), passive Perception 6

Languages: —

Challenge: 1 (200 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

Antimagic Susceptibility: The animated coffin is incapacitated while in the area of an *antimagic field*. If targeted by *dispel magic*, the animated coffin must succeed on a Constitution saving throw against the caster's spell save DC or fall unconscious for 1 minute.

False Appearance: While the animated coffin is motionless, it is indistinguishable from a normal wooden casket.

Secure Lid: As an action, a creature inside the animated coffin or within 5 feet of it can attempt a DC 12 Strength check to open or close the lid. When the lid is opened, a creature inside is freed. The animated coffin can open or close its lid freely if it is not grappled.

Unusual Nature: The animated coffin doesn't require air, food, drink or sleep.

ACTIONS

Slam: *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (1d10 + 2) bludgeoning damage.

Lid: *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) bludgeoning damage. If the target is a Medium or smaller creature, it must succeed on a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw or be captured by the animated coffin, and the animated coffin cannot capture another target. A captured creature is blinded and restrained, it has total cover against attacks and other effects outside the animated coffin, and it takes 3 (1d6) bludgeoning damage at the start of each of the animated coffin's turns.

A closed wooden coffin rests atop a stone bier. The coffin appears to be in good condition despite the dungeon's dankness. Suddenly, the coffin rises on one end, as if lifted by an unseen hand. It hops toward you, its lid opening and closing like the mouth of some great beast!

BAMBOO GOLEM

Medium Construct, Unaligned

Armor Class: 12 (natural armor)

Hit Points: 32 (5d8 + 10)

Speed: 20 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
14 (+2)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	6 (-2)	10 (+0)	6 (-2)

Skills: Perception +2

Damage Vulnerability: fire

Damage Resistances: bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical weapons that aren't adamantine

Damage Immunities: poison, psychic

Condition Immunities: charmed, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 12

Languages: understands Common but can't speak

Challenge: 2 (450 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

Limited Ammunition: The bamboo golem can hold up to six poisoned darts before it needs to be manually reloaded by another creature, which takes 1 minute. When encountered, the bamboo golem can be assumed to have its full complement of darts or a random amount by rolling 1d6.

Magic Resistance: The bamboo golem has advantage on all saving throws against spells and other magical effects.

Unusual Nature: The bamboo golem doesn't require air, food, drink, or sleep.

ACTIONS

Multiattack: The bamboo golem makes two Spear attacks. It can replace one attack with a Blowgun attack.

Spear: *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) piercing damage.

Blowgun: *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, range 25/100 ft., one target. *Hit:* 3 piercing damage, and the target must make a DC 12 Constitution saving throw or be poisoned for 1 hour. While poisoned, the target is unconscious. The target wakes up if it takes further damage or another creature uses an action to shake it awake.

A 5-foot-tall humanoid-shaped creature composed of bamboo stakes stiffly approaches. Its head is a lumpy gourd with carved eyes that glow pale green. One arm is blackened and sharpened to a point, while the other is hollow. As it closes in, a red-fletched dart shoots out of its hollow appendage.

DOGFOLK

Medium Humanoid (Dogfolk), Any Alignment

Armor Class: 13 (hide armor)

Hit Points: 22 (5d8)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
13 (+1)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	9 (-1)

Skills: Perception +2

Senses: passive Perception 12

Languages: Gnoll

Challenge: 1/2 (100 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

Keen Hearing and Smell: The dogfolk has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on hearing or smell.

Pack Tactics: The dogfolk has advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the dogfolk's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally isn't incapacitated.

ACTIONS

Bite: *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 3 (1d4 + 1) piercing damage.

Longsword: *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d8 + 1) slashing damage, or 6 (1d10 + 1) slashing damage if used with two hands.

This canine-featured humanoid wears hide armor and brandishes a longsword. Its facial features more closely resemble those of a domesticated dog than those of a wolf or fox.

PHORCIDES' FOLLICLE

Tiny Monstrosity, Typically Neutral Evil

Armor Class: 13

Hit Points: 55 (10d4 + 30)

Speed: 30 ft., swim 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
10 (+0)	16 (+3)	16 (+3)	12 (+1)	13 (+1)	7 (-2)

Skills: Perception +3

Condition Immunities: petrified

Senses: blindsight 10 ft., darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13

Languages: understands Common and Modern Thracian but can't speak

Challenge: 2 (450 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

Immortal Fortitude: If damage reduces the follicle to 0 hit points, it must make a Constitution saving throw with a DC of 5 + the damage taken, unless the damage is from a critical hit. On a success, the follicle drops to 1 hit point instead.

Petrifying Gaze: When a creature that can see the follicle's eyes starts its turn within 30 feet of the follicle, the follicle can force it to make a DC 14 Constitution saving throw if the follicle isn't incapacitated and can see the creature. If the saving throw fails by 5 or more, the creature is instantly petrified. Otherwise, a creature that fails the save begins to turn to stone and is restrained. The restrained creature must repeat the saving throw at the end of its next turn, becoming petrified on a failure or ending the effect on a success. The petrification lasts until the creature is freed by the *greater restoration* spell or other magic.

Unless surprised, a creature can avert its eyes to avoid the saving throw at the start of its turn. If the creature does so, it can't see the follicle until the start of its next turn, when it can avert its eyes again. If the creature looks at the follicle in the meantime, it must immediately make the save.

ACTIONS

Bite: *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) piercing damage, and the target must make a DC 14 Constitution saving throw, taking 14 (4d6) poison damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

You sense an odd malevolence hiding behind the eyes of this tiny green snake. As you continue to stare at it, you can feel your muscles begin to stiffen.

SWARM OF ANIMATED SKULLS

Medium Swarm of Tiny Constructs, Unaligned

Armor Class: 12

Hit Points: 27 (5d8 + 5)

Speed: 0 ft., fly 20 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
8 (-1)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	1 (-5)	5 (-3)	1 (-5)

Damage Resistances: bludgeoning, piercing, slashing

Damage Immunities: poison, psychic

Condition Immunities: blinded, charmed, deafened, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned, prone, restrained, stunned

Senses: blindsight 60 ft. (blind beyond this radius), passive Perception 7

Languages: —

Challenge: 1 (200 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

Antimagic Susceptibility: The swarm is incapacitated while in the area of an *antimagic field*. If targeted by *dispel magic*, the swarm must succeed on a Constitution saving throw against the caster's spell save DC or fall unconscious for 1 minute.

False Appearance: While the swarm is motionless, it is indistinguishable from a pile of skulls.

Swarm: The swarm can occupy another creature's space and vice versa, and the swarm can move through any opening large enough for a Tiny skull. The swarm can't regain hit

points or gain temporary hit points.

Unusual Nature: The swarm doesn't require air, food, drink or sleep.

ACTIONS

Bite: *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target in the swarm's space. *Hit:* 14 (4d6) piercing damage, or 7 (2d6) piercing damage if the swarm has half of its hit points or fewer.

A cloud of floating skulls drifts down the corridor in your direction, accompanied by the clatter and chatter of countless teeth gnawing at the air. The skulls bob and weave like a swarm of bats, homing in on your position. As the flying cluster nears, the rattle of teeth gets louder, as if the skulls are eager to feast on your flesh!

TARAND

Large Beast, Unaligned

Armor Class: 14 (natural armor)

Hit Points: 71 (11d10 + 11)

Speed: 50 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
13 (+1)	16 (+3)	12 (+1)	5 (-3)	14 (+2)	6 (-2)

Skills: Perception +4, Stealth +7

Senses: passive Perception 14

Languages: —

Challenge: 1 (200 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

Beast of Burden: The tarand is considered to be a Huge animal for the purpose of determining its carrying capacity.

Chameleon Hair: The tarand has advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks made to hide.

ACTIONS

Multiattack: The tarand makes three attacks: two with its Hooves and one with its Bite or Gore.

Hooves: *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) bludgeoning damage.

Bite: *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) piercing damage.

Gore: *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) piercing damage.

This large mammal resembles a reindeer or moose, but the coloration of its fur shifts from grayish brown to match its surroundings, indicating some natural ability to camouflage itself.

WOOD DOOR GOLEM

Large Construct, Unaligned

Armor Class: 15 (natural armor)

Hit Points: 85 (10d10 + 30)

Speed: 0 ft.

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
17 (+3)	1 (-5)	16 (+3)	1 (-5)	14 (+2)	1 (-5)

Damage Vulnerabilities: bludgeoning that is magical

Damage Immunities: poison; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks that aren't adamantine

Condition Immunities: charmed, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned, prone

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 12

Languages: understands the languages of its creator but can't speak

Challenge: 1 (200 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

False Appearance: While the wood door golem remains motionless, it is indistinguishable from an ornate wooden door.

Immutable Form: The wood door golem is immune to any spell or effect that would alter its form.

Improved Critical: The wood door golem's Slam attack scores a critical hit on a roll of 19 or 20.

Magic Resistance: The wood door golem has advantage on saving throws against spells and other magical effects.

Magic Weapons: The wood door golem's weapon attacks are magical.

Unusual Nature: The wood door golem doesn't require air, food, drink, or sleep.

ACTIONS

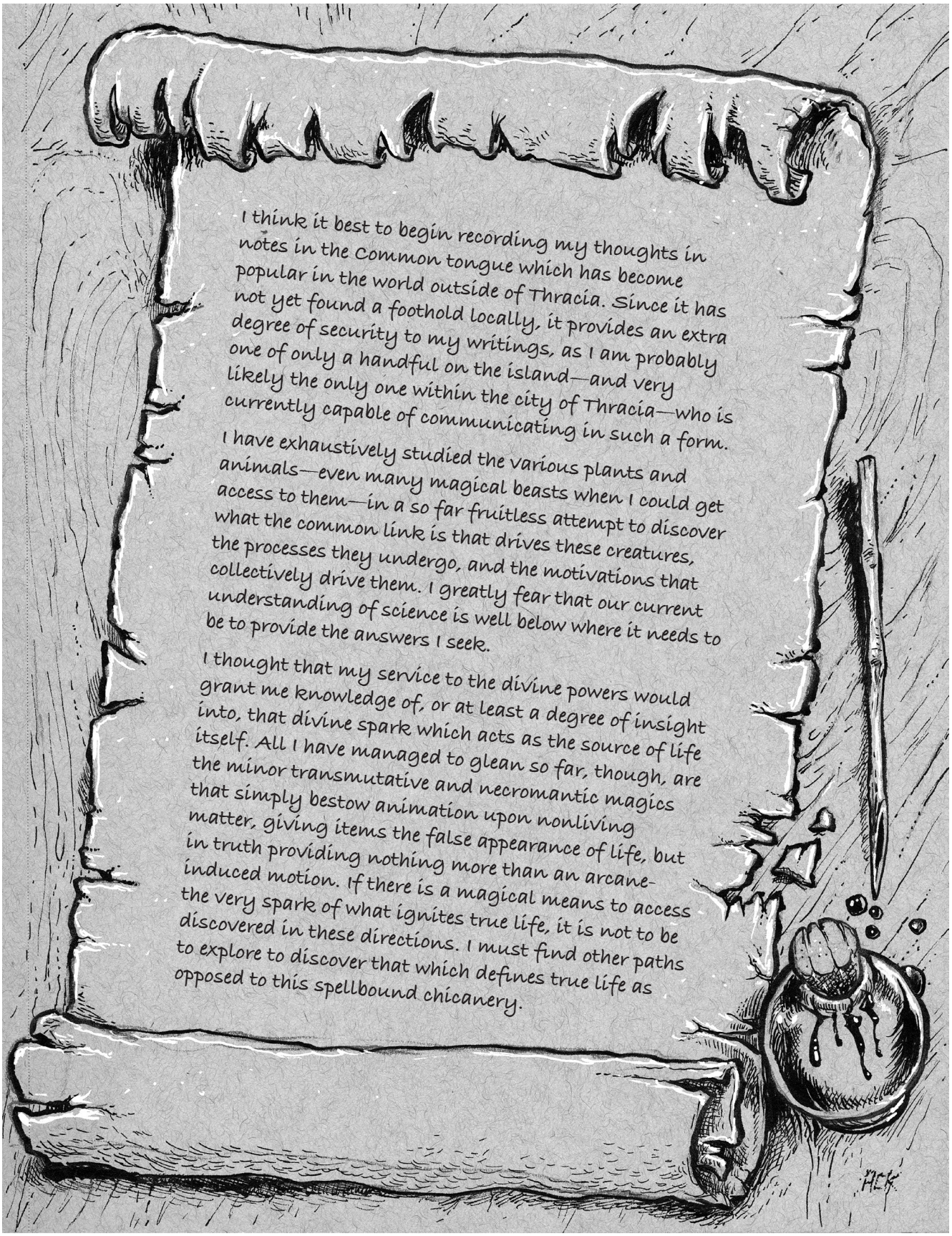
Slam: *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 10 (2d6 + 3) bludgeoning damage, and the target is grappled (escape DC 13) unless it succeeds on a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw to avoid getting stuck in the door. Until this grapple ends, the target is restrained, and the door can't slam another target. A creature that escapes this grapple can exit on either side of the door.

Spellcasting (3/Day): The wood door golem casts *sleep* (using a 2nd-level spell slot), requiring no material components.

This large wooden door is decorated with ornate designs and other high-quality craftwork. It looks to be masterfully made as if hinting that what lies behind it is just as valuable, if not more.

APPENDIX B: PLAYER HANDOUTS

PLAYER HANDOUT 1



I think it best to begin recording my thoughts in notes in the Common tongue which has become popular in the world outside of Thracia. Since it has not yet found a foothold locally, it provides an extra degree of security to my writings, as I am probably one of only a handful on the island—and very likely the only one within the city of Thracia—who is currently capable of communicating in such a form.

I have exhaustively studied the various plants and animals—even many magical beasts when I could get access to them—in a so far fruitless attempt to discover what the common link is that drives these creatures, the processes they undergo, and the motivations that collectively drive them. I greatly fear that our current understanding of science is well below where it needs to be to provide the answers I seek.

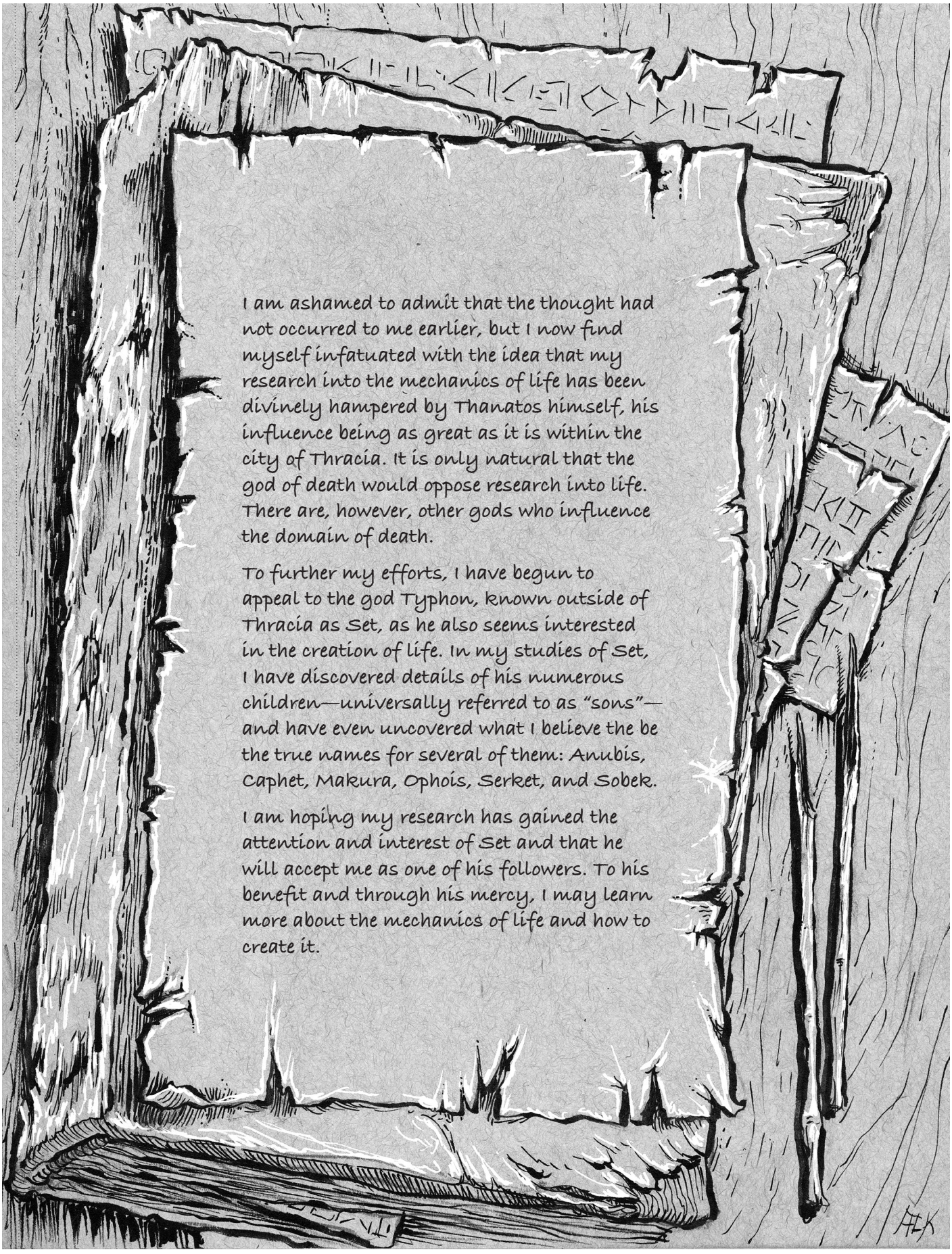
I thought that my service to the divine powers would grant me knowledge of, or at least a degree of insight into, that divine spark which acts as the source of life itself. All I have managed to glean so far, though, are the minor transmutative and necromantic magics that simply bestow animation upon nonliving matter, giving items the false appearance of life, but in truth providing nothing more than an arcane-induced motion. If there is a magical means to access the very spark of what ignites true life, it is not to be discovered in these directions. I must find other paths to explore to discover that which defines true life as opposed to this spellbound chicanery.

I had been second guessing my decision to divide my time between two different avenues of research, fearing that the time wasted in one pursuit would only prevent me from reaching my goal in the other. As it turns out, my concern was for naught; neither path could provide the answers I was looking for.

The creation of constructs—from relatively minor creations like homunculi to more complex golems—had always intrigued me, as the resulting creatures behave more free-willed and intelligent than simply animated corpses or objects. Perhaps what I sought was an element that would be obvious in the creation of such constructs. Unfortunately, although I still cannot profess to fully understand what motivates these creations, the spark I was hoping would become obvious during their creation still manages to elude me.

My second front of research in awakening intelligence within plants and beasts also failed to provide insight into the essential elements of life, although I will admit that I find the act of bestowing intelligence on primitive creatures strangely empowering. Rather than elevate already existing plants and creatures to intelligence, I am eager to begin work on creating my own races of creatures imbued with natural intelligence. Using humans as part of the base material for my research, due to their natural intelligence, I'm certain intelligent hybrid creatures such as men-dogs, or men-cattle, could be created. Perhaps this avenue of research will provide the insight into the source of life that I seek.

PLAYER HANDOUT 3

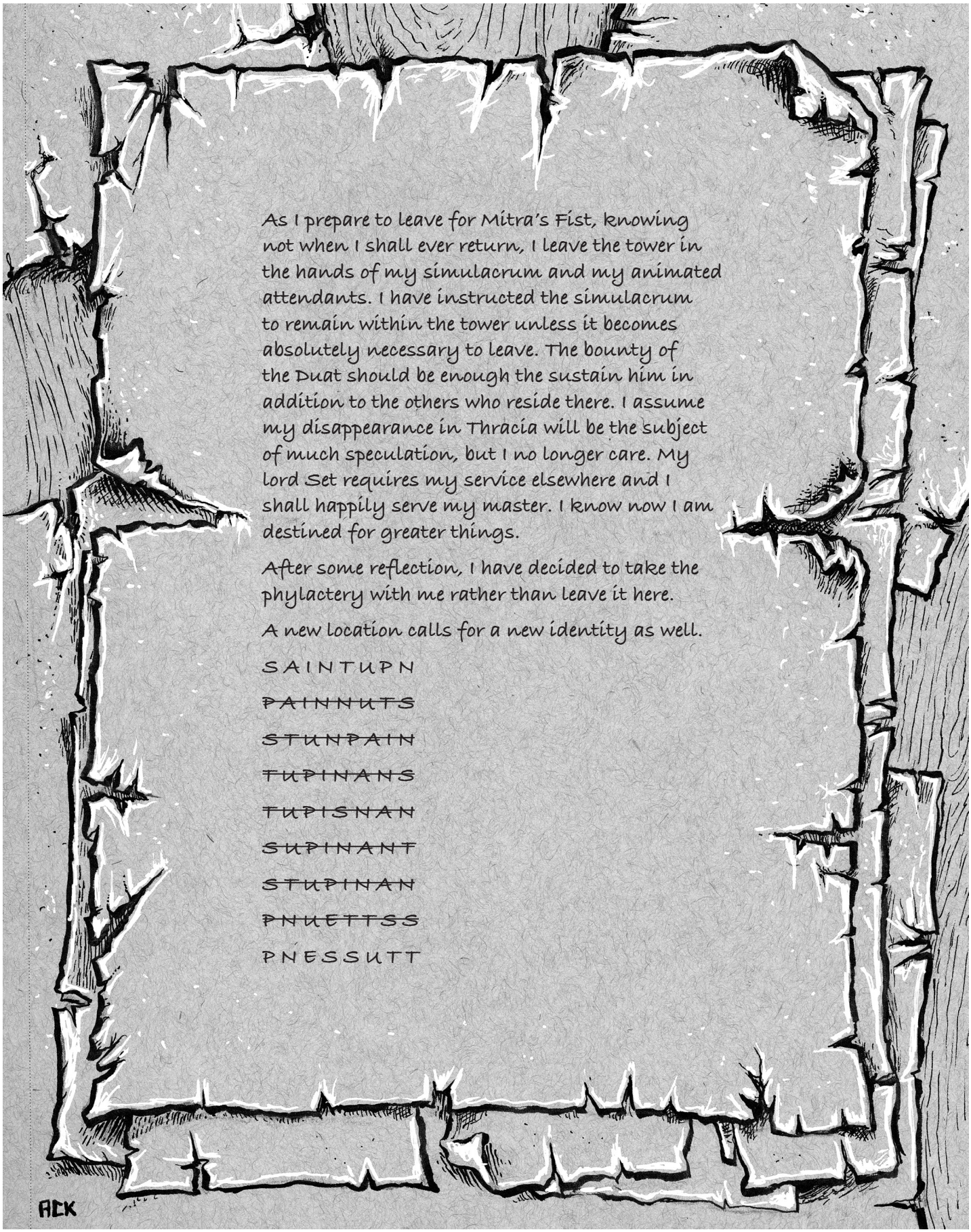


I am ashamed to admit that the thought had not occurred to me earlier, but I now find myself infatuated with the idea that my research into the mechanics of life has been divinely hampered by Thanatos himself, his influence being as great as it is within the city of Thracia. It is only natural that the god of death would oppose research into life. There are, however, other gods who influence the domain of death.

To further my efforts, I have begun to appeal to the god Typhon, known outside of Thracia as Set, as he also seems interested in the creation of life. In my studies of Set, I have discovered details of his numerous children—universally referred to as "sons"—and have even uncovered what I believe the be the true names for several of them: Anubis, Caphet, Makura, Ophois, Serket, and Sobek.

I am hoping my research has gained the attention and interest of Set and that he will accept me as one of his followers. To his benefit and through his mercy, I may learn more about the mechanics of life and how to create it.

PLAYER HANDOUT 4



As I prepare to leave for Mitra's Fist, knowing not when I shall ever return, I leave the tower in the hands of my simulacrum and my animated attendants. I have instructed the simulacrum to remain within the tower unless it becomes absolutely necessary to leave. The bounty of the Duat should be enough the sustain him in addition to the others who reside there. I assume my disappearance in Thracia will be the subject of much speculation, but I no longer care. My lord Set requires my service elsewhere and I shall happily serve my master. I know now I am destined for greater things.

After some reflection, I have decided to take the phylactery with me rather than leave it here.

A new location calls for a new identity as well.

SAINTUPN

~~PAINNUTS~~

~~STUNPAIN~~

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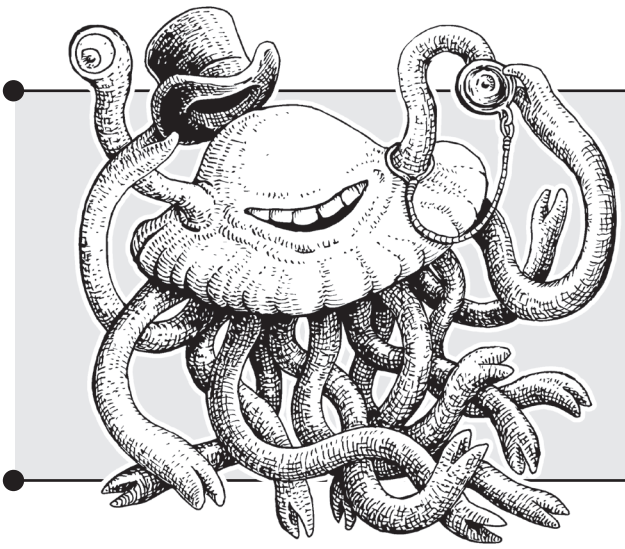

FLOG'S EYE SEES ALL!

News & Updates For Goodman Games 5E Fans

Well met, adventurers! It is I, Flog'istaulc, your personal guide on our journey through this essay. With my enchanted monocle, I observe the natural wonders and numinous curiosities of the multiverse. I perceive ancient histories, recent proceedings, or even things that have not yet come to be. I now focus my lens on Chris Doyle, who quilled this memorandum to Jennell Jaquays.

On January 10th, 2024, the tabletop roleplaying game and video game communities lost a legend, as the news about the passing of Jennell Jaquays was spread. Even the *New York Times* reported on her passing. A tabletop game and video game designer and artist, her writing efforts were published by all the top RPG companies in the late 1970's and early 1980's. She penned *Dark Tower* and *The Caverns of Thracia*, two of the first "mega-dungeons" over 40 years ago, and who can forget her stunning cover art for *Dragon Mountain*? *Dark Tower* was the only non-TSR adventure to make 2004's *Dungeon Magazine Top 30 Adventures of All Time* list. And as for video game development and design, she worked on home console conversions of *Pac-Man* and *Donkey Kong*, plus the *Age of Empires* series and several titles in the *Quake* series. She cofounded the Guildhall at SMU, a graduate-level video game design program at Southern Methodist University in Texas, and was a dedicated transgender activist. She lived a full life and inspired many.

We considered Jennell to be part of the Goodman Games family, collaborating with her on several projects regarding her famous adventures. The news of her passing came a few short weeks before we started to deliver *OAR #7 Dark Tower*, and a few months before we launched the crowdfunding for *OAR #9 The Caverns of Thracia*. Talk about a gut punch, rolled with a natural 20.

I had the opportunity to convert *Dark Tower* to 5E, and virtually interview Jennell in the lead-up to the crowdfunding. I shall never forget that hour of discussing adventure design with a legendary designer. Although she is well-known for creating non-linear detailed dungeon maps with numerous branching paths, entrances, and exits, I posit that her NPC design was just as compelling. Take a look at some of the NPCs she developed for *Dark Tower*, for example. A wizard polymorphed into a chest, but retains some intelligence to interact with characters and cast spells. A pair of intelligent doors set at opposite ends of a hallway, each yearning for a treasure just out of reach. And a dastardly villain that destroyed his body in a magical inferno and now must use *magic jar* to assume humanoid form. I could go on. The next time you examine the numerous levels of a mega-dungeon, or read the fascinating backstory of an NPC, there is a solid chance the cartographer and authors were inspired by Jennell's design principles.

The fact that these beloved adventures continue to be popular today, warranting updated versions and reprints, speaks volumes about Jennell's impact on the TTRPG industry. If someone out there were to consider a "Mount Rushmore" of adventure designers, I feel Jennell Jaquays should be part of that conversation. I consider it to be an honor to work on such legacy products, and the small role I played to bring them to a new generation of gamers.

We shall never forget those pioneers who came before us and laid the foundation of adventure design philosophies we consider commonplace today. Jennell was one of those innovators, and her written words, designs and art shall endure.

— Chris Doyle, 2024

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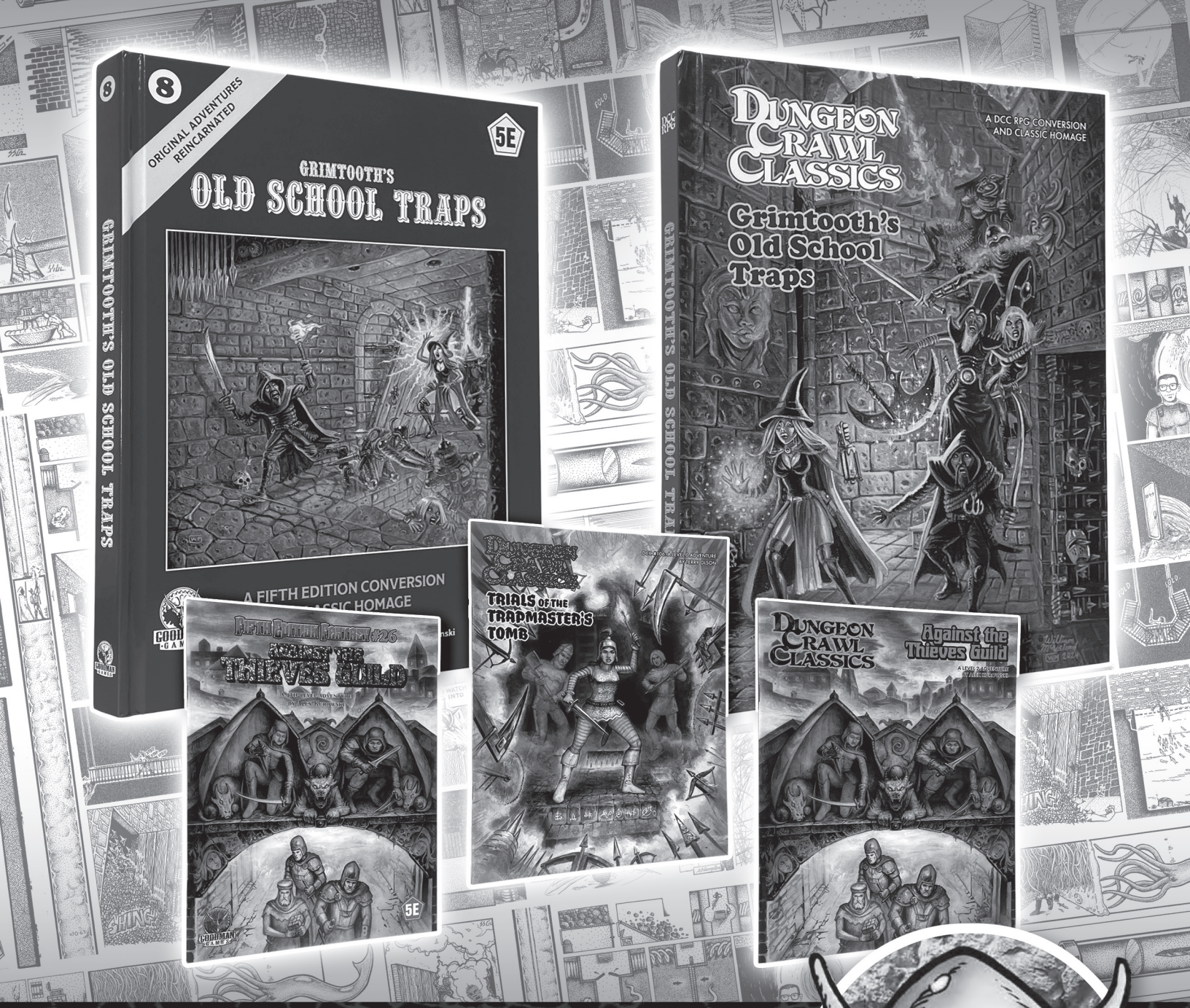

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